

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

us **Central Command** said it had struck targets on Qeshm Island in the Strait of Hormuz. It also said that **Iran** fired missiles at Kuwait and Bahrain, which America “successfully defeated”. It is the first time that Bahrain, which hosts an American navy base, has come under attack since a temporary [ceasefire](#) was agreed between America and Iran. Donald Trump claims peace talks are still “going on”.

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain’s prime minister, appealed for calm after violent protests shook **Southampton**. The unrest followed the conviction of a Sikh man who murdered a white student. Police bodycam footage showed officers handcuffing the dying man after falsely being told he had perpetrated a racist attack. [Nigel Farage](#), leader of the hard-right Reform UK, was criticised for urging “pure cold rage” at the police’s supposed “anti-white prejudice”

Donald Trump picked **Bill Pulte**, a loyalist and head of a federal housing agency, to become the acting director of national intelligence. Mr Pulte replaces Tulsi Gabbard, who announced she would [step down last month](#). While at the housing agency he pushed the Justice Department [to investigate several of the](#)

[president's foes](#) for mortgage fraud. He has no previous national-security experience.

America's federal trade agency proposed introducing a swathe of **new tariffs** following an investigation into alleged forced labour. Levies of 10-12.5% would cover 60 economies, including Canada, China and several European trading partners. The Trump administration has been searching for ruses to allow it to reimpose tariffs since the Supreme Court ruled that "Liberation Day" levies introduced in 2025 [were illegal](#).

The **World Health Organisation** revised down the number of suspected [Ebola](#) cases in the latest outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo. The WHO said there have been 321 confirmed cases and 116 suspected ones. Meanwhile, **Kenya's** top court extended a block on the construction of an Ebola quarantine centre for American citizens for three more weeks. Two people died on Monday in protests against the facility.

An **El Niño**, a weather pattern that raises global temperatures and alters rainfall, is expected to start imminently, according to the **World Meteorological Organisation**. Some forecasts indicate that it could be the strongest such event in decades. If so, it will substantially increase the risks of extreme weather such as droughts or torrential rainfall over the next nine to 12 months.

Shares in **Victoria's Secret** rose by nearly 50%, reaching a record high. The lingerie-seller saw strong revenue growth in the first quarter and raised its full-year guidance. It recently announced that its ticker on the New York Stock Exchange will change from "VSCO" to "VSXY" because "sexy has always been part of our DNA." The results suggest that the bra-maker, after [years of sagging sales](#), is experiencing an uplift.

Figure of the day: 82, the number of people who claim to have travelled to all 193 countries last year. Find out [why travel is](#)

becoming a competitive sport.



Photograph: Getty Images

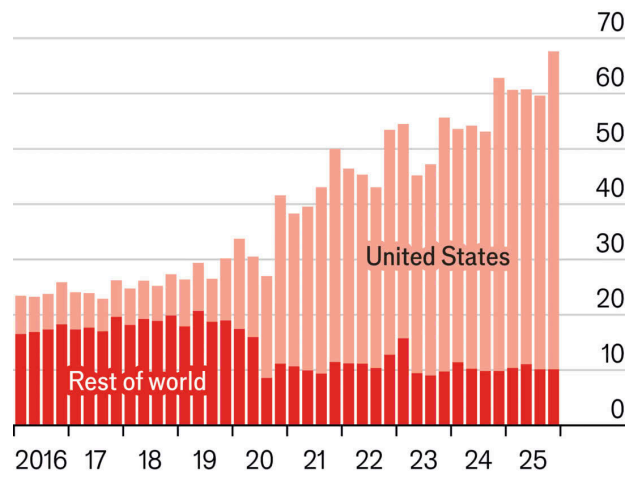
Techxit: Europe's push for digital sovereignty

In the digital technology race, Europe has long lagged behind. Most European consumers and firms are locked into using American digital giants' office software, online searches and (more recently) cloud services and artificial intelligence. But the EU is keen to regain ground. On Wednesday the European Commission will finally unveil its "Tech Sovereignty" proposals, which outline how it intends to make the bloc's chipmaking, cloud-computing and AI industries more competitive.

Arguments over the package mean it has already been pushed back several times. Policymakers are keen to reduce [Europe's reliance on American tech](#), either to protect sensitive data or to boost innovation. But doing so will be extremely expensive. And some worry that giving European companies preferential treatment will aggravate America's government, which has always regarded European regulation and taxation on American tech firms as unfair. It will not like what Brussels is proposing.

American dependence

Euro area, imports of intellectual-property services, €bn



Source: ECB



Photograph: EPA

The global economy looks remarkably resilient (for now)

Last year the global economy weathered the heightened uncertainty caused by a trade war and geopolitical tensions to grow by 3.4%, helped along by the boom in artificial intelligence. This year the war in the Gulf threatens to [supercharge inflation](#) and slow growth. Yet forecasters remain sanguine. Since America and Israel first attacked Iran, inflation forecasts have risen by less than one percentage point. Growth forecasts have been trimmed by less than half a point.

On Wednesday the OECD, a club of mostly rich countries, will release its biannual projections for what's next. It will likely nudge down its global growth forecast from the 2.9% predicted in March, while revising up its previous inflation forecast (4%). America's economy is expected to grow 2%; China's by more than double that. But much depends on how soon a deal is reached to open the Strait of Hormuz. Oil prices, though high, are not yet at crisis levels. But if the disruption persists, they might well become so.



Photograph: Reuters

Taking South Korea's political temperature

South Korea holds local elections on Wednesday, one year since Lee Jae Myung was elected president. His approval rating remains decent; his liberal Democratic Party should fare well. The People Power Party, South Korea's conservative opposition, [is still reeling](#) from the ousting of Yoon Suk Yeol, the former president, after he declared martial law in 2024. Still, DP needs to win key contests, including the mayoral races in Seoul and Busan—the two biggest cities—and parliamentary by-elections with candidates considered to be future presidential contenders.

The results will show how the political mood is changing. Recent polls suggest that South Koreans in their 40s and 50s remain staunchly liberal, but that younger voters, especially men, tilt conservative. They are fed up with the lack of progress in issues such as youth unemployment and housing. Young South Koreans tend to vote less, but with the early-voting turnout at a record high in this election, they may sway results this time.



Photograph: AP

Hopes for a grand climax to the NBA season

The 2025-26 season has not been great for North America's National Basketball Association. In October a coach and a player were accused of [running illegal poker games](#) and manipulating bets on matches using inside information. More recently, the NBA amended its rules to prevent teams from “tanking”—playing deliberately badly to improve their chances of recruiting the best players in next season's draft (lower-ranking teams get better odds).

But the finals, which begin on Wednesday, should give fans something to look forward to. The New York Knicks will battle the San Antonio Spurs in a best-of-seven series. The Knicks last made it this far in 1999; they have not been victorious overall since 1973. The big story for their opponents, meanwhile, is Victor Wembanyama, the Spurs' 7-foot-4-inch French superstar. He was sensational in their recent series against the Oklahoma City Thunder, the reigning NBA champions. Winning the championship at the age of 22 would set him on the path to all-time greatness.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Which highly common animal group is believed to have descended from dinosaurs?

Tuesday: Casement, sash and bay are types of which architectural feature?

*Prejudice is more violent the
blinder it is.*

Elizabeth Blackwell